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Vince DiMartino

Vince DiMartino has led a distinguished career as a jazz educator and master of the trumpet. His teaching philosophy and his versatility in all genres of music have made him an invaluable contributor to the jazz and classical worlds.

Vince was interviewed via Zoom on January 8, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Vince DiMartino with me today. And we're pretending you're in Greece, is that correct?

VD: Oh yeah. My mind is there a lot of times, every day.

MR: Yeah. Well you're a world traveler and you can't see this because it's in front of me but in the wall in front of me I have six pages of your resume.

VD: Oh no.

MR: On the right I have a page of handwritten notes, and on the left another page, and then I have these pages that I don't have room for.

VD: Terrible.

MR: So my first question is how did you fit all this in?

VD: Well first of all, I'm a teacher first. I've always wanted to be just like my high school band director, so I always made sure that I taught all my students every week and never missed any, because that was my primary goal, is to be an asset to that community no matter where I was teaching. It didn't really matter if I was teaching junior high school students I would be the same. And then on the weekends, you know I would teach until Thursday afternoon and then I could get on a plane and I could fly to another university or some concert venue, you know, to play with some other folks: a brass quintet, jazz groups, a solo with wind ensembles, and stuff like that. And then I would come back on Sunday night.

MR: There's a lot to be said for that because I'm familiar with a number of people who are educators but they don't have the same philosophy about that. They will reschedule lessons at the drop of a hat because they have a gig.

VD: Right. Well you know to some degree I very rarely did anything longer than three or four days. It looks like I was gone forever you know, but I did an average of — I remember when I filled out my university forms you know every year they want to know what you've done. I usually had about — between my regional concerts and my other concerts, I had about 80 a year. So it looks like oh my God how did anybody do that. Well if it's just like a local brass quintet gig it just says "and others" you know, but these were things

local, meaning in a hundred mile radius. And then some of them were — you know. And if I did have to leave more than four days I pre-taught my students before I left. I never wanted to be trying to play catch-up you know. That put me at ease both performing and teaching.

MR: I think I know the answer to this question but do you feel it was a positive arrangement for you to be doing these concerts and these gigs and did it affect your teaching and what you could pass on to your students?

VD: Oh yeah. Well you know it depended on what students. I taught mostly music ed students and applied students, some of which are pretty well known performers now. But they had needs and so I had to make sure that the syllabus — I used a very strict syllabus whereas most applied teachers don't do that. You know you come into a lesson and everybody goes, "Oh that sounds better than last week." But you know if you're taking English class they give you a syllabus and there's five books on there and you read those five books and you are responsible for the material, and then you get tested on it.

MR: Did you create the syllabus?

VD: Yeah. I'll send it to you.

MR: And did you create it — going back to this performing that you did in all aspects of music, did that find a place in the syllabus?

VD: Yes in a sense. You know first of all a responsibility of a trumpet teacher, if you're going to study with a trumpet teacher you have to learn how to play the trumpet. And a lot of students come to college and they have deficiencies. So the first two semesters of my syllabus are more or less expository. So everything is set up by keys and by like styles of music. Like I had one book that was called *In the Singing Style*. And what it was, was orchestra melodies, everything from a church hymn to a, you know, some kind of a part of some piece that a trumpet would play in an orchestra or something like that. So this way I could see, you know assess the depth of the knowledge of students in music. Then I would have the technical — we would start out with freshmen, everybody, it didn't matter if they were virtuosic, all freshmen did the same course because you know what the academic ombudsman is, don't you?

MR: I'm going to let you tell me.

VD: Well in most liberal arts colleges they usually don't have one but I taught in Centres so I know that they don't really have them. They have an academic counsel or something you know. But at State universities you know you have to treat everybody equally meaning from the standpoint of the coursework. You can't say, "Oh, well Monk you know you're not a very good reader so I'm going to give you this real easy thing to do and then at the end of the semester you can write a one-page summary of what we did this semester, and

other young person comes in, maybe the class is philosophy. "Well your mom and dad were both philosophers and they wrote books and things, so you have to read *War and Peace* and you have to tell me all the levels that this book is written on." And then the guy that does the *War and Peace* gets a B, and guy that does the easy assignments because they just had no contact with music gets an A. You see that's not fair. Just because that person is able you cannot treat them differently. So I wanted to make sure — and then also you find a lot of holes in that person that everybody thinks plays really well and that's my job. My job is to bring everybody up to a certain standard. That's what a course does. You have to learn as an applied teacher or any teacher in college you have to learn how to use their system to make what you need to happen happen. And over by you know like some people will turn in a syllabus that will say, "Fresh veneer, fundamentals." What's that? I mean that's nothing. That's say like, "Let's eat." You know what I mean? That's fine but I mean I guess it's effective but for that one situation — but I would say, "Let's go to my favorite French restaurant. They have crepes. Crepes are this wonderful thing that you put stuff inside or on top of." You see what I mean? You have to create depth if you are going to do something extraordinary.

MR: Well in 1973 when you sort of started out was this philosophy in place?

VD: Well no, it was — first of all I learned that the students couldn't play the pieces that I knew. That was the first thing I learned. Well some of them. You know there were three or four that were good students, really. And they played the kind of literature that I knew. And the next person would come in you know I've never heard him play before and they obviously needed remedial work to play a moderately difficult piece, not even a difficult one. Even less than medium. So I started to really study literature. Because you know when you go to conservatory your teacher hands you the Haydn Trumpet Concerto or they hand you some other piece, the Tomasi Concerto where — "Oh you can play piccolo trumpet? Oh you're going to play the Brandenburg Concerto" because they might be able to. But see like I said, you don't find the shortcomings by only exposing a small part of what that student knows. Because it's like students, when I used to practice when I first went to Eastman I didn't want to sound bad in a practice room. All I ever played were things that I felt like I could — you know I tried to get those things better. And I knew I couldn't play below the staff worth a darn so I didn't really do that too much because you know, so that's what you try to learn by setting up a syllabus. Because it's very expository. You know it shows what the student can't do. So even though they're using the same syllabus, later, when I developed it a few years down the road, when I had my first sabbatical that was the very first thing I did. Because I was sort of doing it but it was still a little on the hodge-podge side you know. I had music ed students, so I had to figure

to transpose." "Well I don't need to transpose." I said, "Okay here's this score, tell me what note the French horn is playing in concert pitch." "Oh. Oh let's see, that's a" I'm going —

MR: Time's up.

VD: That's right. I'd say — the kids are way smarter than we are. I said, "If you can't read the score they know it." Because they know what their instruments can do and you don't. Count lines you know. I said, "You can't do that. You want to be an extraordinary band director. That means, it doesn't mean you're a genius. It means you're out of the ordinary. There are no geniuses. There are extraordinary people. You know?

MR: Okay I'm quoting — that's quote number one today. I love it.

VD: So I developed this — eventually I developed this syllabus. And the syllabus was to put everybody in the same course so that they had the same materials that they had to know as a graduating trumpet player or band director, and/or band director. You see what I mean? So that this way — now that said, the materials that you had to be tested on, and it's in two-week modules — so the first week they come in and I say, "Well how did you do on the materials this week?" Because that's the first week. See? Like so in other words you had two-week modules, the same material. That's the only time you get to do that material. Then you get tested on it the second week. But if they're a student, okay, that is fairly advanced. If they took private lessons they're going to sail through the first stuff, except for maybe the things that they don't do so well like, "You know your articulation is really not that good. You can play faster than lightening but you know but it's not really clear what you're doing." So you can use them — especially if you use material that is familiar, very familiar to the teacher. You uncover those problems much easier, see? And then you can get right to the root of the problem on the same material. Now the next person I might say, "Well gee your lip slurs on that piece are, you know you really don't have the right air, so let's work on that to make sure that you have a tone line, that it doesn't sound like" [scats]. I said, "Do you talk like that? Let's go eat." "Okay." I said, "You don't talk like that, do you?" I said, "I'm not making fun of you but" I said, "that's what music is, people hear you and they have to understand what you're saying. And the way they do that is through the evenness of your voice." So we have to create that and so all these materials, and then at the same time those materials in the first two weeks are only in C and G. It was — because they were familiar with those keys. I want to put them at ease. I don't want them to feel like you're going to do C and C sharp today. These first two weeks. And they play C and they feel good and then they play C sharp and they can't even play the scale. See? So I wanted to make sure it was progressive. You know it progressed to — they were learning discipline training, because they only had two weeks

See what I mean? So you're adding accidentals and you're adding the appropriate etudes that are in those keys. So they're playing like in that key for two weeks. They don't have other keys. And then they have to learn it. So the reason, once again, is to put everybody on an even keel. When you go to English class and you're the worst reader in the class it takes you longer to read the books. It takes you longer to understand reading faster what's going on. It takes you longer to understand the plot or whatever, whatever your weakness is. But hopefully the materials, if they're chosen right by the teacher, will allow you to start figuring out what needs the most work. Of course you go to lessons and that's really what we talk about.

MR: I'm going to leapfrog to after you've had these students for years perhaps —

VD: Yeah, four years.

MR: Okay. Have you ever had students who get to the point who can play things that you can't?

VD: Not really.

MR: Okay.

VD: Not really, and that's because I mean I don't expect all my colleagues to do what I've done, which is my own passion for playing. I mean I — people would say to me, "Why are you in Kentucky?" I'd say, "Well why are you anywhere?" I said because you can be an asset to that community. When I stepped foot in Kentucky and started that it was a one-year appointment. And I knew after the first month that I didn't want to leave because there was activity in the trumpet there but it was not anything extraordinary. And so now I think the thing I feel the best about, besides the students that are teaching at other universities and playing in service bands and professional groups and things, other orchestras, I think my greatest achievement is having enriched the community in which I live. What could be better? You know I found out my neighbor, he plays all over the world. You know after you've lived there for twenty years. Because he'd never played there. You know he'd go out on these trips and traveling, and then you play one recital a year at the university you know and that's it. And then nobody comes to that most of the time except other faculty and friends. So basically like I started a duo there because when I got there there was nothing for me to play in in Kentucky. It was 110,000 people in Lexington and now there's almost 400,000. So I said well I've got to do something here so I'm going to volunteer to play with high school bands. I just visited in Florida here with the band director of the first concert I did with a high school band in Kentucky. Excellent band. And he asked me, and his son played trumpet. So I gave his son trumpet lessons and you know I played with him at the Midwest Band Clinic. I played with all the best bands in Kentucky at the Midwest Band Clinic. And to me that was the greatest

that teach in schools, that are excellent teachers. I have students that teach other young people about trumpet. I have students — all the students in my big band they were students at U.K. See? And they wouldn't be in there if they couldn't play it. Because they know me better, and it's like my son, right? You know he's a great trumpet player. He taught at — I think it was Colgate, I'm not sure.

MR: Syracuse I think he was at.

VD: He was at Syracuse but he played in an orchestra that was either in Hamilton or Colgate, I can't remember. Because I went there but I wasn't there in the day I was there at night just to hear his rehearsal.

MR: I see.

VD: I did go to Colgate when I was in high school though. I went to American Legion Boys State.

MR: All right.

VD: And I played a solo with the band at the All-State. You know you got appointed by your local county. I don't even remember. But I loved it up there. All I remember was you had to walk up this hill.

MR: Yes, lots of hills at Colgate.

VD: And it was hot. And I was trying to figure out how I could only walk up the hill once, you know, because it was so hot there. You know and I'm from New York, from Long Island you know so we knew what the summers were like but not like that when you were walking up that hill. We didn't have those hills on Long Island.

MR: Well I want to ask you, as a kid I had a couple of moments that really put me on a path, it was fortunate. And I read this anecdote about you had a semester away and you were in Bogota, Colombia.

VD: That's right.

MR: I'd love to hear the details about this story.

VD: It's a good story because it really relates to my life choices. And that is, when I was in high school, you know I was a good student. And so you know that's how I got to go to Bogota, the school sent me for free. And they sent another girl who was one of my good friends, she went to Guatemala. And I was sent to Colombia. They chose two students and for different reasons. I wasn't the highest academic in the school, but I was up in the classes with those people. And so I went. I was getting ready — my dentist, who lived on the wealthy side of the street, the big street, you know he was a dentist. And his daughter was one of my best friends. We consulted on our homework at night you know. "Oh man, that trigonometry, that question number six did you —" you know and that kind of thing. "Did you get the answer to that? I kept getting this X — that ain't it, you know what I

gosh." But her dad was a dentist, okay? And you know I told him and I said, "Well you know I want to be either a doctor or a dentist." You know I figured I want to live on that side of the street, that's a pretty good place to be. So he said, "Well you can come over, and come to the office and you know see what I do." So I went like once a week or once every two weeks, and I sterilized his stuff. Now they just throw it away and use new ones. But you know he had a sterilization thing and you put all the used instruments in there and then he can use them for the next patient or the next day or whatever. And he also gave me a nice white coat that I could watch what he was doing. And I wasn't really excited you know about the stuff lying around in people's mouth and everything. But I said well I can do this. I can probably do this. And I said well maybe I'll go to a medical school and be a doctor. And I said well that's not going to be any easier you know. So that was my junior year, and I went between my junior and senior year. And so I went down to Colombia. And it was about — I forget what the name of it — it was called the Open Door Exchange Program. And so you know there were about I don't know, twelve, a dozen other students from different places on Long Island you know that went to the same place. And we had meetings and they took us on excursions. We went to Cartagena from Bogota and stayed about like two or three days and saw all the beautiful things there on the coast. But the family I was staying with, they had a sort of a — almost like a small cottage in the lowlands. Because Bogota is like about 7,000 feet up in the mountains. It's about like Denver or something. And it rained there every day for about ten minutes and then it was absolutely gorgeous the rest of the time. And it was that way all year long. So they would take us down to the coast and they were kind of wealthy. There was a little country club there. And the place we stayed in was rustic at best. Spartan. I used to call it the "Spartan Arms" because you slept in a hammock in some of the rooms, and they had a swimming pool. The only thing that was there was they had their own swimming pool and they had this block, cement block cottage thing. And you could fit about five people in there and some of them sleeping in the living room. But the country club was great food and they had like traditional dancing there. So it was kind of neat. So after I'd been there a month man I wasn't playing with anybody. I wasn't doing anything. So there was a dance at this big hotel, the Hotel Tequendama. And it was a, you know at the time it was like "the" hotel so if your school had a dance they did it there because it was their big deal. And so I went and they had this cumbia band that played that music and I said, wow that's really interesting stuff. I heard that on the radio and I said now I'm watching the musicians do this. And I told them I said, "Well I play trumpet you know." So they said, "Well you can come back." I said, "Well yeah, I played in the like All-State groups and stuff like that in America." He says, "Well you can come back if you want to try to

"Oh boy you sound great." And I said, "Well," I said, "I'd like to play somewhere." And they said, "Well there's a place, it's not in the best section of Bogota but it's called 'Freddie's American Jazz Bar' and they have a trio there that you might like to listen to at least." And I said, "Well that's great." So I found my way over there, and I didn't, you know this was great because you know the families you were staying with, they didn't want you going to like, almost like going to Harlem or something. You know what I mean? They didn't want you going there. They had glass in their wall around their house because you know crime is a big thing. They didn't have a regular police force there. Military police. They carry machine guns. You know they walk around the city, you see these guys with machine guns you know. At night you hear [scats]. Sometimes you know I'm going I'm glad my mom and dad didn't know about this you know what I mean because I didn't know either. So anyway so I found this place and I went over there. Same kind of thing. They said, "Well you could bring your trumpet and we'd see what you do." And I played a couple of tunes with them and they said, "Can you come back every week?" I said, "Well you know I have a lot of friends and we only can get together, I can only go out at night when I go out with my friends." So if you will feed my friends — and you know it was a bar like, you know it was like a nice place but it was a bar. And he said, "Well we usually don't have a lot of young people in here." And I was about 18, 17. And I said, "Well can't you make a place where they just sit?" "Okay." And every time we'd come, almost every week and I'd come there and the table would be filled with food and I'd play and all my exchange student friends were there and they loved it and the people started coming you know. And so I said, "You know I really like doing this. This is what I really like to do" I said. And putting the thing in somebody's mouth and seeing blood fly around with pieces of their teeth, that just really, I don't think — what's the choice here you know? So I had already, when I went back I talked to my mom first, I said, "Mom you know I don't think I want to be a doctor." And she said, "Well that's all right." I said, "Really?" She said, "Well you know look at you're a really good student, look at what you've done on trumpet, look what you've done in school, why would I be worried about what you're going to do? You're going to do well." You know and she was great. I said, "Wow, thanks for that, Mom, you can tell dad." You know it was really funny. And my mom was really the center of our whole family, even the grandparents and everything. Because she had the joie de vivre. And when she said, "Oh come on we have to get together on Sunday, come on out from the city (my grandparents)."

MR: What was that descriptor you just used for her?

VD: Joie de vivre?

MR: Yeah.

MR: Okay. You must have not been a person who was afraid to take a chance, to basically improvise?

VD: No. I didn't learn by reading music. Because even though I started in the public schools you know that was sort of fundamentally [scats] and but my neighbor was a bass player. My back neighbor where I would climb over the fence and he had a little jazz group that he would rehearse. He was like an engineer at Sperry Gyroscope out on Long Island. He played bass. Genius. He was telling me about how they were working on the gyroscopes that would send the rockets up and stuff. I mean he was great. But my dad said to him, my dad was a tap dancer during the war, overseas. I mean he did everything from being a cook to a tank driver, and he would entertain tap dancing when they were doing some sort of event to keep everybody upbeat. You know? And so what was I saying — so he asked the bass player, in the back, he said, "Hey Bob, you know my son's been playing trumpet and I think he sounds pretty good, so is there any recordings that I should have, I should get him?" And we didn't have a lot of money. So he named like four recordings and it was Miles Davis, Maynard Ferguson, Rafael Mendez and Billy Butterfield.

MR: Oh, nice mix.

VD: Yep. That's why I think he, this guy was like I say, he was really organized in his thoughts and his work. So I had these four records, you know the LPs and a changer. And every day after school that's what I did. I practiced. I did my homework first, always. My schoolwork. And so then I did my trumpet until dinner. I did my homework while my mom was cooking I did it in the kitchen at the table. And she was cooking and I said [sniffs] "Oh what is that, Mom? That smells really good." And that's how I learned to cook. I never cooked for many years except by smell when I finally started to cook a lot I just remembered what it smelled like. I said, "I think this is close." And then, "I think that was too much garlic maybe." So I would practice with these records at least an hour a day.

MR: Can you define what you were — how were you practicing? Were you copying?

VD: Yes.

MR: You were trying to get what these trumpet players were playing?

VD: Yes and I thought that I was like the worst trumpet player that ever lived, because I couldn't play a lot of the stuff that was on the records. Try to play along with Maynard Ferguson and I'm going, "They don't even have the fingerings in the book for this, so how am I supposed to do this?" You know. So I said, "Well I'll just use the ones an octave lower." And then it worked and you know so, and I played in band, in middle school band and when I finally — I remember when I was in middle school band that we were reading like a simple march book, the Bennett Band Book I remember it was a little,

started playing and I said what? How come there's three eighth notes in a beat? I don't get this. Because it was 6/8 you see. And I didn't understand how 6/8 worked and — I could play it, because once I heard somebody play it I figured it out you know. But I really was, I mean I always practiced. When I was in junior high school I practiced at least a couple of hours a day. At least. And I listened. See? And I always tell people today, no matter what lessons they're taking, I say, "Practicing is a good thing." I said, "If you only like to practice a half hour a day and you just want to learn to play a little bit and play in a group then you only have to listen a half hour a day." I said, "If you want to practice more than that then you have to practice the equivalent time listening. Otherwise you have no vocabulary. All you have is words. You have just words and they don't make any sense to anybody." See you know and the inflection, I said, "You have to learn the vernacular language of whatever is on the recording." If I'm listening to a classical symphony — which I did — I worked at Lockheed where my dad worked, Lockheed Aircraft at Kennedy Airport when it was there, before they moved. And I was the receiving clerk one summer. And I had one of those — you know those radios that have the antenna was the handle?

MR: Oh yes.

VD: Well that's what I had. And it was green and it had that patent leather all over it. And I used to listen to WPAT, New Jersey, which was right over the river from the airport. And it was all classical. Because by that time I was going to go to Eastman. I was in Eastman at the time. And these guys, they had to come and they had runners for parts you know. And they would come and say, "I want this part here, number 4 —" I said, "Wait," I said, "what is that music you're listening to? I said, "That's the music you're going to have to listen to before I get your part." You know cement heads I was working with. But I understood. I understood all that. But I listened all the time. Because when I found music, and I tell students the same thing. I said — I listen to rock & roll. And the reason I did was because well I was a kid and we all listened to rock & roll. And I said, you know these chords that they're playing, some notes stay the same and some notes change. And most of the time they don't change much. So I was learning theory right away. See? And I learned to play with those ideas in my mind. So well that note stays the same almost the whole time. I can work off of that note you know what I mean? I was clueless, you know?

MR: Sort of anticipated a question I had about that and that was especially in the rock & roll or the jazz is playing the trumpet parts, or playing along with it, was there a point where you got a sense of also hearing the bass notes and figuring out okay this is in mostly this key that's why these trumpet parts sort of make sense?

VD: Yeah. My first job was when I was 14. Okay? With older musicians. Because I lived about 400 yards from an American Legion — no it wasn't an American Legion — it was like one of those little party houses. Not a big one, just a little one. And they would have weddings in there and you know the Italian club would meet there and you know things like that. So one night about 9:00 the phone rings and some guy is talking to my dad and he goes, "Absolutely not." I'm going what's going on, what's going on? He says, "No, my son's not coming out at 9:00 and play with your band. I know you heard he plays pretty well but well okay, I'm coming over there with him." So he took me over to this place and you know what? My neighbor had given me a fake book. See I did that after school too. I learned some tunes. I didn't really know the chord changes at all really. So the very first thing I heard from the band leader, "Oh thanks for coming. 'Perdido' in B flat." That was all I had.

MR: Did you have a B flat fake book?

VD: No, no I had a C.

MR: So you had a concert fake book, did you read?

VD: I transposed it. So then I had to play off the staff. And my band director of course in high school, okay, he was great.

MR: We should get his name on the record.

VD: His name? Edward DeUlio.

MR: Ilio?

VD: DeUlio. Large D, small E, Large I — L-I-O. U-I-L-O. DeUlio. And I mean I think of him almost every day, still. Because he was just remarkable, a remarkable person you know. And he would say — anytime I had time I was in the band room practicing. During lunch I would eat lunch in 10 minutes and I'd go over to the band room and practice. And that's just what I did. And he had one of those rotating lesson schedules so that he could have the groups of kids that played the same part, he could work with them and teach them, you know give a little more instruction than just playing in band and not getting the part. You know what I mean? So he had a rotating schedule and so if I came down there and there was a group in there he'd go, "Go teach the saxophones, go teach the alto saxophones." And I'd say, "I can't teach them, their music is in a different key." "Well you'll get it, don't worry about it." That's all the instruction. 'Cause, and then the next guy, you know who Glen Drews is?

MR: Yes.

VD: Okay he sat right here in high school band. We were together. You know? And we were pretty good. And then the third guy, he could barely play a G on top of the staff. He was one of the first trumpets too. And then the guy that was the fourth one — it was better

That was his forte, besides playing trumpet. He played trumpet. I didn't take lessons from him 'cause — he would have probably given me lessons but I didn't really have any money. We were poor you know and I had a paper route and I bought records with that money. That's what I did. Every day when we finished when I had collected the money for the papers I knew how much I had to pay for the papers and I knew how much was left. And I'd go directly to Abraham & Strauss. Abraham & Strauss was a department store in Long Island and it probably is other places. But they had a record department. Unheard of today. But I would go there and I'd look through the instrumental section.

MR: Me too.

VD: And I'd find — oh look there's a new Harry James record. I've got to have this. You know and then the record collection kept — and when I gave away my records, except for the ones that are sort of collectors' things for me I had over 800 of those. I have way over a thousand CDs. And now, with all the digital stuff, I don't even know what I have. I have 15,000 pieces of music that are catalogued.

MR: Okay take me back to "Perdido" because I'm curious as after you played the melody did the band leader say, "Okay you got it."

VD: No he said, "Can you play a solo?" And I said, "Well if somebody else plays first." Because the wheels were turning for me, right? You know? And I don't know why but they were — I said well I'm going to figure out. So I heard it and I said, "Wait, I can play that, that's in C, the beginning of it." You know? Oh yeah, this middle section's got some different chords in it. But it's got some Es in it. So you see what I mean? So I was playing like the outline. But it was great. And I played with that band for years. I played with these musicians, and they would play with different groups, and I imagine they must have said, "Well look at this young guy, he can play pretty well and he knows the songs." See so I could play the melody even if it wasn't — because every day I'd learn a couple of tunes. I'd transpose them because I said if I get called to do something now I've got to know the tunes.

MR: But just so we have this story complete, do you recall what you were paid for that first —

VD: Oh yeah, it was about $18. 18. It was under $20 I remember that.

MR: I'll bet it was more than you were getting on the paper route. Say that again?

VD: I felt like a millionaire. Because my friends were working at McDonald's for $1.25 an hour. They were working all week and I made more money than they did just playing for two, three hours. Sometimes four. But you know I did sometimes two things on a weekend. So my little sister, she's 14 years younger than me, I could buy stuff for her, I'd go to the fish store and get some good fish for — my mom loved fish and I love fish. My dad never was a big fish person. Anyway, even when I came home from college, I never

went home first. I went to the fish store. And when I pulled in the driveway the first thing I did was take the fish in. You know what I mean?

MR: I don't know that sounds fishy to me.

VD: It is. And you know it was great because I felt like that was a good function for — and I bought some records occasionally you know and stuff like that. But mostly I used it to feel like I was helping with the family stuff you know. And I think that's a good — and I tell students this all the time. I say, "Look, the most important thing is to be an asset to your community." I say "It doesn't matter if you're on Carnegie Hall stage that's a community. Make sure you're doing what is necessary to be an asset to that group. If you're playing with a junior high school or conducting a junior high school band make sure you're an asset to that community. If somebody dies in your community and you can play at the service and you know that person especially, you can volunteer to play." I still do it. You know? Because when they finish that service invariably people will come up to me and say, "Oh my gosh when you played the 'Ave Maria' it really helped the whole where I was." You know? And you go what could be better than that? That's real. You go on, you know I go play with some orchestra let's say, and I love playing with orchestras. And I played in Carnegie Hall a lot of times. And I even played solos with the Cincinnati Pops in Carnegie Hall. And you know the whole time you're there you see these people just — remember when — I'm thinking well I like Haydn's Concerto but I think Joe Smith, you know, I like the way he plays it better. They're not there for the record, they don't have any — but you know somebody who you've touched in a situation like a funeral, a wedding. I don't do weddings anymore, I hate wedding coordinators. They're awful. But you know they tell you what to do and I say, "I'm not doing that. I'm not going to stand where the bride is supposed to come out and play from there. Do you want everybody to look at me before they look at the bride? It isn't going to happen." With her dad, you know what I'm saying?

MR: Yeah. You know you made me think about when I look at your resume and your list of accomplishments and things you've done, I wonder if there's a difference in your mindset in your preparation and your whole demeanor from playing — I know a mutual friend mentioned that you had played "A Soldier's Tale" — a Stravinsky.

VD: I didn't do it with Stravinsky. I played Stravinsky [inaudible]. There's a recording with Syracuse Chamber Music Players that we did.

MR: So when that's coming up for you, even the day of it, is it a different Vince than if you're playing with the Clark Terry Big Band? Is your head space —

VD: The person is the same. The character is wearing a different costume. I'm acting. Playing music is acting. Because you're in a scenario, you're in a landscape — see in a landscape

sudden there's a picture of a bicycle in the middle of it. That isn't going to make it, unless it's just for shock. You know what I mean? It's to shock somebody or something. But in general, and some people like that kind of art. You know what I mean? But my job is not to do that. My job is to honor the composer. Jazz, classical, if I'm backing up Billy Joel or somebody. One of my friends who lives in Florida, that's what his job is, Billy Joel. And you know I played with rock & roll groups: Bobby Rydell — [sings] it's only the joker — and those people, we're talking about Sonny & Cher. You know when you play with these groups, you're never playing Vince DiMartino. I hope not. You're playing their music the way it should be played. That's all. And that's what I like. So that's another reason I taught trumpet because I tell people I said, they said, "Well you know I really don't like" such and such and this and that. I said, "Okay" I said, "tell me what kind of music you're going to be playing in twenty years." They go, "Well I don't know." That's why you have to learn trumpet. Unless you don't want to play trumpet anymore in twenty years.

MR: Well said.

VD: Well you have to kind of jolt people sometimes because you know they're enthusiastic about what they're doing but they're not practical. You know I'm thinking about okay what's the most important — oh there's my wife, hello, Miss Patty.
[inaudible]

VD: My wife. She's the greatest. The best. So you know the most important thing is just what we're doing is your family, your relationship with your closest group, whatever that is. Family, group, you know maybe it's a singles group. I don't know. But that's important.

MR: Yeah.

VD: And maybe this is the right thing. And people always quote me on this, even when I'm not there. Because they realize that it's true. Music is something you do in between meals. That's the way I think, every day. Meaning your life is first, your music is part of that, but it's not the total focus. Because if it is you end up being extraordinary in a not-so-great way sometimes. You know somebody who is walking around, you know they're just not aware of anything that's around them, you're doing a beautiful place and they're going, "Well you know that rehearsal was too long and I don't like that conductor." Well that's okay if you don't like him, I can tell you I don't like the conductor, that's it. I'm done. You can converse with them a little bit but you can't rant forever about stuff that — you know and then they end up, that's why I went to school to study orchestral trumpet. Not jazz. I went to study 'cause I knew I was weaker in that. And I liked orchestral music. I listen to it all the time you know, as well as some jazz things, as the more I listened. Got more than those first four records, and the radio. The radio was so helpful.

And so I went to Eastman and I was just different than a lot of the people but I had good friends there you know.

MR: How were you different?

VD: Well that's what I'm going to tell you. So most of them studied with orchestral people. There weren't many jazz people there because they didn't have a jazz program then. Jazz had to meet on Saturdays and you didn't get credit for it. And you know so basically, you know it was I don't want to say anti-jazz but it wasn't part of the curriculum at first. I was there during the transition to having a wonderful jazz program. So I go there you know and they were all talking about my teacher said this. And I was the person, I'd say, "Man, what's that trumpet you're playing? Why did you cut off your tuning slide?" And they'd laugh. They said, "You never seen a C trumpet before?" "Well no" I said, "I've heard about C trumpet but I thought it just meant transpose up a step." So you know what I mean? My whole growth was what do you call that, natural. It didn't have any organization to it. My organization was there's no trumpet in that. I wonder why there's no trumpet in that. You know what I mean? I was back-door learning. I'd say, "Wow that's a string group" and then I'd start studying, listening to these string quartets because I was interested. And when I played in the orchestra at Eastman I didn't know anything about a lot of the instruments. I was a music ed major, thank goodness, because I took every instrument for a little bit and it helped me — actually it helped me to play with other people in the future. But so when I was in orchestra, you know it was like some of these people have a terrible attitude. Then I started playing extra, with a local orchestra in Rochester, and they seemed like, you know they were reading *Golf Magazine* when they had rests and stuff, and I'm going, "I like this music. I don't think they like this music." You know of course I'm young. So that's my perception. And then I noticed sometimes they wouldn't pay attention and it wouldn't get — you know I don't want to live in this little town 20 or 30 hours a week with this group. This is not my close group that I want to be in.

MR: Isn't it interesting that you can learn things from negative experiences.

VD: Exactly. And of course I love playing brass quintets, I love playing recitals. I've played, I've probably — 150 to 200 recit — maybe more. I never counted. I played trumpet and organ for 25 years with a good friend of mine at U.K. We had a National Endowment for the Arts grant and we played all over the country just doing recitals. And I played at least 10 to 15 recitals a year, I must have done at least 400 then. Yeah. So I probably, but it was never like I was counting them it was just something I looked forward to.

MR: Did you ever have the experience, especially when you started out, playing, you know, contract things to play behind a performer. This happened to me when Aretha Franklin

VD: I played with her too.

MR: Yeah. And I got to play in the horn section. And I found that I can't look at her because if I do I'm going to get enthralled and I'm going to miss like eight measures.

VD: Yeah. There's a certain — well you develop a work ethic so to speak — maybe it's probably a work ethic, or there's probably a better word for it than that, but it would be like when you do certain things. When I play brass quintet there's nothing I'm thinking about except where I'm going. And that's why the concentration factor in brass quintet playing is very challenging. It's harder than playing recitals with just a piano and trumpet. Maybe not — physically it's just as much, almost the same, okay? Because you never rest much. If you're playing first trumpet you just play all the time. And you're playing the high part you know so that that concentration — so when you play a show like Aretha Franklin there's a lot of places you don't play. So that's when I listen to Aretha Franklin. The rest of the time — and there's really, there's another part to it, the part that makes your trumpet work, see? Let's see I've got that background thing there. [whistles] See? The trumpet is not a visual instrument. Music is not visual, it's sonic. So if you have to look at the music and see Cs and Gs that takes too long. That's too long.

MR: Say that again?

VD: Yeah. So basically there is no — okay let me show you. Okay. Follow this music and I can't find a piece of music, all right? Okay. So okay. You here?

MR: Yes.

VD: You hear the music?

MR: Oh —

VD: I do. [scats] So that's what I hear. Because that's what this represents. That's why they teach solfeggio. They teach solfeggio because it bypasses visual. It's not visual. It's music — if you're looking for music to make sound, all you do is you crumble it up and put it in your fireplace and you can hear it burn. Really. 'Cause it doesn't exist. This is a shortcut for people to play together or to practice certain things that people think are important. And that's all. Otherwise it'd be like, "Okay, we're going to play Beethoven Fifth. Okay? All right violins and strings, you play [scats]. Okay, now let's learn the next bar [scats]. Oh you're having a lot of trouble with that. Okay let's try that again. [scats] oh it's the same melody. See I already recognized that it has the same shape [scats]." Most people go [scats]. But that's not what he wrote. Because if you're listening to the notes, the sound, you relate it to [scats]. But he said it a hundred times already. You see? And when I work with a conductor that doesn't bring that out, they're not good. That's so simple. See they've been taught by somebody who didn't teach them music. They taught them how to rehearse. How to get people to play together.

VD: You see what I mean? And then of course half the orchestra knows [scats] and the conductor doesn't, they don't even watch them because it's destroying the music for them. He's going [scats]. He's putting the agogic so that you're hearing every downbeat and it's not [scats] if you were going to conduct it, but they don't. You don't have to conduct it. You have to trust the musicians to make that happen. And if they don't do that that's when you tell them, it isn't [scats], it's [scats]. And also they go [scats] and that's how I learned how to play phrasing too. I watched, we had a lot of rests in orchestra. I watched the bows and I saw how they phrased it. And when you play like the Hindemith Sonata is a perfect example of that. Okay? Everybody's slurring the stuff all over the place and I'm going jeez, that sounds so sloppy. And I hated the Hindemith Sonata because I didn't like the way it sounded because I'd never seen it of course. You know what I mean? It was too hard for me to play when I first heard it I remember playing that thing, it's too hard. So then I got a copy of it you know, and I said how can you play this [scats]. Now what happens when you move the bow this way and that way? You have an articulation. I don't care how smooth you are. [scats] And then l[scats]. You see what I mean? When they go this way, that's the slur with the dots.

MR: I see.

VD: That means the bow moves in one direction. I've had some interesting conversations with some really fine trumpet players. I say look, of course they'll be talking about maybe they're recording or something. I go, "Well how come you didn't play it under one bow?" They go, "What are you talking about?"

MR: Right. You didn't understand the language.

VD: They didn't work on it first of all, hard enough, because they may be first trumpet in some orchestra and somebody asked them to make a recording of it and they could play it, physically they were fine trumpet players. But the most important thing, and that's another reason why I used the books that I could teach them this, to the band directors and to the people who were going to be professional trumpet players. See because it's the same. You're teaching music. You know? They have to be musically strong and then you don't have to have a band director that plays the trumpet to learn to play the trumpet right. He taught the flute players, my band director. He taught the saxophone players. They all were good musicians. We had about 50 people in our band usually, because it was a small school. West Babylon was a tiny little part of Babylon but it was a little, own separate school district. And we only had 50 people in the band. You know our marching band was in the smallest category and stuff. And about every year about ten percent of that band went into music. Like the thing with Glenn Drewes and me, okay, if either of us, the band director would conduct here and the trumpets were sitting over here right

average as it always did. And then he'd look at us and never stop the band. And I'd say, "Glen, I think we did something wrong." Because that's all he would do. He'd never call us out in band. But you know people couldn't play the same part — he never said anything to them because he knew why they were in band. So it became a really inclusive band. We were all close. The ones that played well and the ones that didn't. And then I'd go home I'd say, "Mom, he looked at me today." She knew what that meant. You know what I'm saying? Because he knew that I was going to take that music home and I was going to dissect the section he looked at us at and I was going to try to find what he — see that was the point. See I didn't know what he was looking for. So I was looking. He didn't say you know you missed that lick there. No. He didn't tell me what was wrong. I didn't know if it was an articulation, maybe I was missing an accidental or something. Usually not, because I played by ear mostly you know. I just knew what fit in and what didn't. But you know or some rhythm wasn't exactly right. And I'd come back the next day and I'd go okay I'm going to see if he's going to look at me in that spot. I mean it was like a game for him. He knew. He had everybody's number. See he had it all in numbers. This kid didn't want to go to band because he didn't want to go to study hall because he'd get beat up. He might be a little, like a little meek person. That's what went on in those days. There were a lot of bullies.

MR: Yeah. Well we've been at this for about an hour, and I wanted to fit in one last —

VD: Whatever. Whatever you want to do is fine. I can talk all day, as you know. Go ahead.

MR: Sometimes this is hard to remember, but in your lengthy career, can you recall — I'm going to use a couple of adjectives here. The most bizarre gig, the worst gig, the kind of gig you come home and tell your wife, you go, "You can't believe what happened on this one."

VD: Most of them are — some of them are funny you know. Like one of them was the most depressing job for me personally okay? I get called, once again somebody was sick. It was in Rochester when I was a student. Somebody is sick and this guy calls up and says, "Can you come and play over at the 50 Acres" which was the big barn-like place you know what I mean? And they had weddings and different kinds of things, just like the first job I ever played. And so I showed up and the guy that was running the job, he was about 85 and he played violin. And I noticed that Joe Benedetto, he was the Vice President of the Musicians Union, was playing. I said, "Oh, I know Joe, at least I know Joe." You know? Because I didn't — and everybody in that group was — except for Joe, he was about 55 at the time — was over 70. Everybody. And there was no book. Okay? So the guy says, "Thanks for coming. Do you know the 'Black Hawk Waltz'?" I said, "No." I knew a lot of tunes, and this went on. I think I knew one tune in the first set. And

the ones that I did know I could really play. And then of course I could play solos when he wanted me to play a solo, but I couldn't play the melody ever. I'd say just — but you know I'd listen and then I sort of sometimes I could play like a part of the melody because I figured it out just like I did the first job. I used the same technique. And then Joe Benedetto, he was sitting right next to me. The saxophone player? He says he knew what was going on and he said to me, "Vince, I have only known two or three tunes and I'm 55." You know and so, he knew, because I was like 19 or something like that you know. And it was great. But it was depressing because I couldn't really contribute anything you know what I mean? I just was sitting there. As a matter of fact I think I told the guys, I said, "Look, I didn't do very good tonight, you don't really have to pay me, I really played only about five tunes that I knew and I played some solos and that's all I did." He says, "Oh no, you sounded very nice." And that was it. I said, "Okay whatever," I said, "I could use the money." But that was a terribly depressing job. Another one that was right with my dad. See my dad was a tap dancer and he was in the American Legion and like I said, I played pretty well when I was 14, like I could play, if I could play like Bunny Berigan, I could play "I Can't Get Started," I could play "Hey There" down an octave from where Maynard Ferguson played it. And I mean I could play all these characters acting you know. And so they had a little group that would go out to the veterans' homes, the, you know the mental hospitals and stuff, all the different kinds of things for veterans mostly you know what I mean, where they might be. And so we would go out. And we went to this one hospital, which is infamous actually, and it got closed up. Pilgrim State Hospital out on Long Island. It was a big expose, maybe 40, 50 years ago on the Pilgrim State, how horrible the conditions were and everything. So we're in this place right, and we start playing. And when I play people were starting to like scream and stuff. I didn't know where I was. And it was horrifying. And I was going, "Jeez I'm hurting these people, I don't know what's going on." You know because they were reacting to the music. They liked it, because they told me later, they said, "No, no," the people that ran the place, they said, "we haven't had this much excitement out of the people." But for me on the stage it was horrifying. Because I thought I was like hurting people. Because trumpet is not the softest instrument. I thought I was — you know because sometimes the band director would tell you to play softer you know. So that was it. And one of the most exhilarating times was when I realized that you know sometimes I had to play some really hard solos. And I was already teaching at U.K. but I played in Cincinnati Pops and a lot of the recordings I did you know and the solos I did with the orchestra, well they played them in Carnegie Hall so I got to play those solos with the Cincinnati Orchestra in Carnegie Hall which you know that's a little more nerve

was this thing called "Portrait of George." And I didn't record it. The guy that did record it was one of the greatest trumpet players I ever heard in my life and he lived only in Cincinnati, never left there. And he died young. Somebody shot him in a bar. But this guy was the most amazing player I ever heard. So I was channeling my Frank Brown you know but I said well I'm pretty nervous about this. And the first thing that happens in this piece, "Portrait of George," it's George Gershwin, three tunes. And it featured a trombone, a sax, and a trumpet. They were all the three best people in Cincinnati you know, at the time that that recording was done. And of course he was gone, so the other two guys were there and me. And so I'm getting ready to play and the first thing that happens [scats] to the high F. All alone. In Carnegie Hall. And I played off stage. So I was saying oh crap there is no off stage here in Carnegie Hall. There is none. There's the one stage but it was on the other side of the stage. On my side there just was this door. And Erich Kunzel was conducting and he saw me standing there and he goes, "What are you doing? You've got to get off stage." I said, "Well there isn't any off-stage." "There's a door over there. Go open the door." I opened the door and it was the janitor's closet. And in there there's this old lectern that, you know looked like it had been dented a thousand times from banging into something. And then there was the custodian's mop barrel filled with water and smelly mops. So I go in there and I started laughing. I said I'm in Carnegie Hall janitor's office. And Kunzel's going, "What are you doing in there?" Because he wanted me to start playing because, you know we only had a little dress rehearsal in there and then we had to play the concert that night. I said, "Oh I'm getting ready, Erich, I have to set the music stand." Because I didn't bring my music stand in there. There wasn't any music stand. And so that laugh sort of changed my life. Because I realized hell I'm in a janitor's closet, what's the difference between playing in a janitor's closet and on stage? It doesn't make any difference. And so it was an enlightening moment at the right time for me. It was just the right time for it. You know my grandparents were out there and you know stuff, and my mom and dad and my aunts and uncles. All the Italian — the whole Italian crew was there. So it was fun.

MR: Yeah.

VD: The last couple of them right there is probably — and then of course when I played my very first big recital with the organist, I got there and I looked out and it was in the big concert hall. I was expecting the usual, you know, 50 people. There were like 500. And it was so exciting to see all these people. And I was a little nervous for that but at the same time I was going wow, this is great, you know, look it. I said, "Schuyler," you know, and he was a very, the organist really helped me with that too. Because when I was at Eastman I really couldn't even say "trumpet," I would be nervous. You know because I

everybody else had so much training and I was self-trained almost. And my trumpet teacher was absolutely wonderful. He understood where I was, just like my band director did. He was great. So I've always lacked confidence even though I was first trumpet in the jazz band, you know I played first in the second orchestra, I played in the best brass quintet, but I didn't have the confidence that should go with that you know. So when I finally realized that I could play some, it was great you know. And I had moments like that at Eastman but it was hard at Eastman.

MR: You know there's a small number of people I've met over the years, including people like Milt Hinton —

VD: Oh I played with him many times.

MR: Yeah, and Joe Wilder.

VD: I wish I'd met him. Now that's the guy I wish I'd met.

MR: Yeah. He was marvelous. And people — these people I'm describing, every time their name comes up people always have a, "Ohhh, Joe Wilder" or "Ohhh, Clark Terry."

VD: That's right.

MR: So I'm including you in that group, Vince, because I've talked to three or four people before this interview and they all went, "Ohhh, Vince man, that cat —" so you have led a remarkable career and spread a lot of positive energy over the years to a lot of people. So I want to thank you for that.

VD: Well thank you. You know the reason is because I think if your mission is related to people and you care about what they're doing, that's the vibe they get. Because I always wonder, I say I'm just doing what I'm supposed to do I thought. I thought everybody did that. Because I can say that's how clueless I really was and still am sometimes. And the thing with the syllabus too that I wrote and all of that, I said, of course with my background, and I tell people this I said, "Do you know where Viper, Kentucky is?" And they go, "No." I said, "Well they have a stoplight there and there's a gas station. And I want a trumpet player who lives in Viper, Kentucky and has no help, to be able to learn to play trumpet by the words that I've written in this book. It has to be written in human language. Not some esoteric music trumpet guru type of stuff. Otherwise who understands that? That's not their vernacular. You know? So for me that was always the most important thing. And so when they came to school, even if, you know, one of my students said something I'll never forget. He was a freshman, okay? And he was playing his jury, you know his jury exam. Every semester that you take applied lessons you have to play for the class faculty and then they give you comments and they try to help you and, you know, that's great. So and what I used to do, especially with the freshmen that I knew were nervous playing their first, you know, jury. And they're standing up on a stage

played one because everybody gets on stage once at a big recital that everybody plays on, and plays all or part of a movement of a piece and only with the trumpet players there as their audience. So anyway they've been on stage. But in the meantime they haven't been in this situation where they're getting graded for it, you know, and stuff. So I get off stage and I said, "Well, John, what are you going to play?" And he goes, "I'm going to play that there Heyden song." And I realized where I was, you know what I mean? He never said that in, because I never asked him that question you know. And I felt bad because you know the faculty, one of them laughed you know what I mean? And I just — oh gosh this is awful. I said, this isn't going to happen to anybody. I have to teach people, you know, how to — and I never said, "Haydn song" in lessons. You know but every time a student mispronounced a word, I said, "Oh no, that's not Heyden" it's Haydn. I said, "I used to say Heyden." But you're going to say Haydn.

MR: Yeah. Make them feel okay about it, yeah.

VD: After that, after than, and you know when I do master classes it's the same thing. I'll go in and I'll say, "You want to sound like that? This is what you do to fix that." And they try it and they go, "That's pretty good." Well how did I know how to fix that? That's what I used to do. I said, "All the things that you all are doing," I said, "I used to do." So don't think that I'm some sort of a savant or something. I said, "I just spent an extraordinary amount of time wasted trying to figure out how to do it right." And I said, "And I'm glad I did it, because I don't want you to do that. I want to be a catalytic person in your life. I want you to skip all the bad things that I did to try to learn how to play the trumpet." I said, like for instance, like the book that I wrote, it's not a book, it's just a manual for the students to read about how the trumpet works and stuff like that. But I don't want, most of the books that I've ever gotten/bought, I have every book known to man. Like I said, I have 15,000 entries in my library at home. So I've got a lot of books and pieces. I said, "You know most of them don't have much writing in them at all, they just, you know like play these magic etudes and you'll be better." No. You'll be better at playing the way you play and hopefully getting half the notes and still sounding bad. So I said, so the book that I wrote, everything in that book, if you play it wrong it sounds bad. It's just going to sound bad. From the beginning to the end, it's one technique. But nobody knows that. They're just trying to learn all these new materials and I'm working on the same thing every lesson using the materials to fine tune what I should be talking to them about. Because once again, the materials are remedial to start and then after we get along I can even give them more stuff, they get less entries in the lesson thing that are longer, but they're longer. See? So you start out with short things they can do. [scats] You know Arban '93. Yeah. So the old '93. Now I don't even know what pages are

can complete the C and G line on that page. That's all you have to do. C and G. So it's a discipline study. You have seven elements that you get tested on, and they're all — sometimes a page, sometimes a half a page, sometimes one line, two lines off a full page in all the keys. So they're always doing page 93, 125, and 142. They're always doing that, every week, but only two of the keys. So they learn the whole thing by the end of the semester rather than say okay I want you to learn all of page 93. They can't play in half of those keys. They're going to just hate trumpet, they're going to hate taking lessons. And if they practice, they won't because they catch up to the ones that don't practice that are already can play those things. They think they can.

MR: When we're done here, are you going to go practice?

VD: Do you know what I was doing when you came on? I was doing this, which is what I did last night. I played a Baroque Trumpet Recital, a 19th century recital. And I don't play this a lot, you know. So I was playing mostly the low parts and they were playing the moving parts. Now I said, "You know I should really learn to play this more," because I was playing the cornet solos at the end too. There were four of us. So we played baroque trumpet pieces for four baroque trumpets. I said, "Look, I can't play the real hard parts," I said, "'Cause I don't really practice that that much." So as soon as I got home I said, "Man" — I practiced it for that recital and everything. And I said, "Gee I should be able —" so I was practicing this. First you play the harmonic series to know where you are.

1:24:35 out — trumpet playing

1:34:54 in

VD: You cannot practice music without practicing technique. You cannot practice technique without practicing music. See because I was doing like a lip slur exercise, you know they call them lip slurs, they're really tongue slurs. But I was thinking about what it's supposed to sound like to the audience. See? But at the same time when I'm practicing I'm finally tuning my engine. You know my brother raced cars at Bonneville Salt Flats. He built the cars. And you know he'd go out there every year and he'd come back and I'd say, "How was it?" You know. "How'd you do?" He said, "Well you know I'm up to like one-ninety-something now, (in the class he was in). I said, "Did you, you didn't win?" He goes, "Oh no." He says, "the guy that won, he was like almost 208 to 209. He was somewhere in there." I said, "Aw you'll be able to get that by next year." He goes, "No." He says, "Do you realize how much work it takes to go up just half a mile an hour?" And people that are discerning builders of engines, cars, suspensions, you know, alignment and everything. He says, "I might someday get close to that." Right. And I said, "Steve," I said, "this is just like trumpet playing." I said, "It's great. I'm going to use that." I did, I used it in classes you know when I taught master classes you know and stuff. But it's

that, I said, "And eventually the mechanical part is behind you always, it's more passive in the presentation. So I said, "When I play, even if it's an etude," I said, "what's the use of practicing—

[plays]

well that's very nice, I mean it's exciting. But what if I made phrases out of it, I played a little slower.

[plays]

see I mean it's a whole different thing.

MR: Very musical.

VD: Yeah, the other one is just like achtung. You know stop.

I'm going to let you go.

MR: This is awesome.

VD: Your demeanor is so wonderful, I could talk to you all day. You have the right —

MR: I'd love to do it in person sometime.

VD: Well the next time I'm up in that area I will find you.

MR: Please do.

VD: How do you know Greg Caputo?

MR: We connected through an Arts In Education program and we ended up doing some school concerts with a program that I worked with in Central New York, and we backed up Joe Wilder on a little tour.

VD: "Gentleman of Jazz" I used to call him.

MR: I'm telling you he is one of my favorite people in the whole world.

VD: Everybody. Clark Terry.

MR: Yup.

VD: Clark Terry used to tell me. I'd say, "Who did you like?" He says Joe Wilder and of course Snooky. And then he mentioned Cadillac Williams. And I said, "Who's Cadillac Williams?" I said, "Cadillac Williams?" I go — he said, "You should check out Cadillac Williams. He played with Duke Ellington's band." So I bought this five volume set of Duke Ellington records. I'm trying to think of the name of the tune, I think it's called "Brown Betty" if I remember right. Sounds like Clark Terry. I think it was his mentor when he was in the band.

MR: All right.

VD: You know he was great to me. I mean I have to tell you, you see that video? That one with where I played the solo right after he did?

MR: Yes.

VD: Okay, well the other guy that was in there, that played the bridge, that's Richard

MR: That's right. I remember that from the liner notes.

VD: Yes. And when I played with Clark — with Lionel Hampton when I was, you know like 19, the band was Jimmy Cleveland, Julian Priester, Jerome Richardson came one time to be in Lionel Hampton's big band at the Riverboat in the Empire State Building. And I was playing with Lionel Hampton. Paul Cohen, he was the lead trumpet in Count Basie at the time, so when he was in New York and they weren't on tour he'd just play gigs around New York and I mean it was amazing. The whole thing was amazing, just that I could be in the band let alone — and then Lionel Hampton — oh I could tell you a million stories of Lionel Hampton, with Gladys, with his wife.

MR: Yeah, we'll do a part two. We should do it.

VD: These stories with Lionel Hampton are unreal. Because I was like this little kid. You know I was scared of half the people in there because they were kind of rough. And I really wasn't rough, you know. I was naïve and just trying to play good. And Wallace Davenport, did you know who he is?

MR: Yes.

VD: Okay well Wallace was on the band, the small group. After I finished the big band job he asked me to play with this small group, and Wallace was the other trumpet. The guy was unreal. He could circular breathe on double high Cs. I go, "Wallace" and he was super nice. He studied French all the time on the bus. And I said, "Why are you studying — are you going to France?" He says, "No, no" he said, "I'm going back to New Orleans and a lot of the people that I hang out with, they speak French and I'm going to get much better at it." And then he moved, maybe six, eight years later he moved back to New Orleans and stayed there the rest of his life and played in traditional jazz bands. You know I was lucky because I was the end of an era.

MR: Yes.

VD: You know the people after me, except maybe four or five years after me, were still getting jobs with Woody Herman and, you know Buddy Rich and Maynard Ferguson lasted a lot longer. But the young people today, they don't get to play, really they can play with a pop star if they're lucky to get a gig with them. And you know they play a few other things, but I mean we were playing all the time: dinner theaters, you know, all kinds of stuff. So you know that's why it's important — see I never played in Lexington very much because if I played some of the students couldn't go out that were ready to go out.

MR: Oh Vince, I never thought of that.

VD: Yeah. And so even the rhythm sec — I never had good rhythm sections. I had to train them so when I did go out it was with the students. And I'd have a short rehearsal, okay

we're playing a fashion show. Because I said well this is a good gig for them because they're never going to see one of these for a while.

MR: Yes.

VD: I said, "Now this is what we're going to do." I said, "I'm going to have a list of tunes for you and we're going to go over them tonight. We're not going to go over them, I'm going to show you how they go and how we're going to do it and what you need to do and when you need to stop playing each tune and start playing the next one. So you know we did that and they — you know little blips here and there. I did a dance program with one of those with a jazz dance thing. I said, "Well we're going to play these tunes and we're going to rehearse, because we have to rehearse, and you get paid a little money for this." Usually it was the money I was supposed to get. You know? But it was because that's part of their education. And Roland Kirk came to town.

MR: Oh my God.

VD: Yep. Roland Kirk. It was a jazz club, it was called The Fishnet. This guy just loved jazz. It only lasted a few years because not that many people were coming. And I brought the whole big band to play the opening of Roland Kirk in that place. And I'd never heard him play live, I mean I was like oy, yoy, yoy this is great oh my God and he's playing all these saxophones you know. And the kids were going — because I said, "Well this is going to be a happening for you now," I said, "you'll probably never see this again." So I said, "Pay attention. Watch and listen 'cause this guy is unbelievable." And I was the one going, "Oh my God, how'd he do that?" I mean he had all the saxophones set up and he'd play two notes with one finger on each saxophone. It must have been some just Rube Goldberg you know thing. I mean, but it was fun to listen to you know he had that manzello, that thing with the —

MR: Yes and the stritch.

VD: The stritch, yeah.

MR: I saw him one time in Rochester and I think people were so stunned at the end of a piece he'd get this little bit of clapping and he says, "Thanks for that little pitter patter."

VD: Well you know who I used to see at — I can't remember the name of that place, was it the Glass Onion? Rochester?

MR: Yes.

VD: I saw Bill Evans every year. He came every year for two days. I never missed any of the shows. I would sit there and pay them again to see the second show. And most of the time he'd play different music anyway. Oh it was remarkable. You know Rochester was — I'd go to the Pythod.

MR: The Pythod. You know I'm from Rochester.

MR: Yes.

VD: So you know Vinnie Ruggerio and all those guys?

MR: Yes I know Vinnie.

VD: Vinnie, oh man.

MR: Both of my daughters live in the Rochester area.

VD: Oh I love Rochester. I haven't been back since I taught at Eastman, summers. Did you go to the Arrangers Holiday at all?

MR: Yes.

VD: That was one of my favorite things to do.

MR: Yeah.

VD: Because we sight read music and then we recorded it immediately.

MR: Right.

VD: So it was always a challenge. And the trumpet section, my favorite trumpet section was I played, Joe Mosello, Jeff Tyzik, and Al Vizutti.

MR: Couldn't get anybody good, ey?

VD: That was the summer section. And it was great because I was sort of the lead trumpet at the time. And I'd say, "Al, you've got to play this one. This one is — we're only going to do it twice" I said, "we want to get a good recording for this guy," I said, "I might mess this funny technique place up." You know? "Oh, okay." And he'd just kill it. I mean you could turn the music upside down and he could read it. Allen Vizutti could play, because he played the way I'm talking about only his mind was like ten times faster than mine could ever be. And you know Jeff Tyzik could play like the stuff that was more contemporary sounding, you know like the latest kind of fusion stuff. And Joe was a player like me. So we would switch off and then we'd all switch off. When we played shows none of us played strictly lead, even though at the time the lead trumpet in Rochester musicians union, I refused to play first trumpet after a while. Because you got paid the same amount and they had these people — they had people that were working in the theater every week when it was easy. And they'd only call me or Al or Jeff or somebody, you know what I mean, when it was too hard.

MR: Oh.

VD: So I said you know — so then they started calling me and I'd say, "Okay I'll play fourth trumpet." They said, "No, no, we want you to play first." I said, "Well why should I play first? It's easier to play fourth. Just have the people that you normally get play first."

MR: Mmm. Why do you think we called you?

VD: No though then I talked to Al and Jeff and Joe and I said, "Tell them the same thing I said." So what would happen, the first few times you know they wouldn't hire us. And

there's no trumpets here, I have to bring in trumpets and somebody's not going to work." So just think about that. So then they didn't want to pay. See they didn't want to pay so Chuck Mangione actually — I made a proposal to the musicians union. I said, "You know if a saxophone player plays and he plays clarinet and saxophone he gets extra money. I said "That's good, I said, "I think that's right." "Play three and sometimes get double scale for that." So the second tenor player is making double scale and the lead trumpet player, which is a special skill, is making scale. And so is the fourth trumpet player. I said, "I don't get that." I said, "I'd rather play fourth." This was a musicians union meeting. And they went, "What do you propose?" I said, "I propose that the lead trumpet gets 50% over scale or something equivalent like that." We get paid for flugelhorn but they tell us not to use it. You see what I mean? Because it would make the contract bigger.

MR: Yes.

VD: And then Chuck Mangione was there, he came and he supported that. And I don't know what it is now but I'm sure it's been rescinded, but the lead trumpet got 50% over scale. So when we played together we took that 50% and split it up.

MR: Aww.

VD: See? And then we could get through any show.

MR: All right.

VD: Because they would hire all of us then — and the other two guys maybe that normally played, so we would split it whenever there was two of us there. And when there were four of us there, like for some other show, like a dinner theater that wasn't the normal, the War Memorial or the — what was it, the Shrine Auditorium. Oooh lookit, who's this? And then he'd give you the finger. John Cummings. Do you remember him?

MR: No.

VD: He led the Shrine band, and I was mortified. He was crazy.

MR: Wow.

VD: He was a good musician. You know who was the best though? Oh boy. The guy that was a car dealer and he played trumpet? De — de something. He was amazing. He played in the Shrine band.

MR: Did you happen to know Roger Eckers?

VD: Oh sure, he passed away.

MR: Yeah, he was my private teacher.

VD: Oh wow. Roger — and you talk about somebody who was an operator. Roger tried to get around town man, with Gap Mangione, and between those two — but what was that guy's name, oh boy, Italian guy, it was an Italian guy. Played — I never heard anybody

played like a Harry James song, oh it was just great. And I heard him play with the Shrine band, at the Shrine Circus. And I was playing in the circus band, right? And I hear — and at the Shrine, they would go all around the inner circle of the circus and play you know marches and stuff. But you know most of the people in the Shrine band couldn't do the circus part. It was too hard. And boy I wish I could remember. This is terrible. I'm getting senile.

MR: Well I have the same thing. But anyway, I've got to run, Vince.

VD: Yeah, you've got to go.

MR: But this has been a real pleasure.

VD: Yeah, you too. You too. This is great. And the thing you're doing is really great. There's a Skidmore poster back there, isn't there? Is that a Skidmore poster back there?

MR: No that's —

VD: I used to have one like that.

MR: That's concerts that we do here at Hamilton. And I got Joe Williams on this side and Count Basie on the other side.

VD: He asked me to play lead trumpet once. Count Basie.

MR: Yeah.

VD: In person. Because my jazz band was the warm-up act for Count Basie at U.K. So my students, you know I didn't play with the band very often, 'cause that would be a solo that they couldn't play. I mean they wouldn't be on stage learning. So — but after my first year there one of the students says, "Well you should play a solo with us." You know they'd heard me play, I'd demonstrate, you know I'd say that phrase, let me play it it'll take a lot less time to do this.

MR: Yeah.

VD: And they knew I could play. And after they heard me to play with Clark Terry because he asked me to play. That very first year that I played with him, that I was teaching. But the next year I wasn't playing anything. They said, "How come you never play with us?" I said, "Well because you wouldn't have a chance to play another solo, you know I like to feature one of you playing a solo, a saxophone, a trumpet, a trombone you know, and if we do that then there would be two trumpet solos and we don't need that. We need — and I'll feature different people as they're able." You know? So they said, "Yeah but you go all over the country and you play with other people's bands, right?" And I was like oh my God that is so true. I never thought of it, you know what I mean? It was so simple. All I was worried about was what they were doing. You know. And it was great. So I said, "Okay, once a year from now on I will play with you." And that was a good thing because it showcased the jazz band and it was a good recruiting thing for anybody that

pretty good. And I played a solo with them. And Count Basie asked to see me. And I said, "Wow, I'd love to meet him." So he says, "Wow, young man, you sound really good" he says, "you know if we have an opening on the Basie band, would you like to come and play lead trumpet with us?" I said, "Well you know I'd really love to do that but I can't do it during the year because I really love what I'm doing here. But thanks for asking," I said, "that's a great thing" you know what I mean? So I'm happy just to get asked you know is like having done it almost. I know you've got to go.

MR: Thank you very much.

VD: Next time I'll have a better picture.

MR: I'll just pause here and we'll say our good-byes.

VD: Yeah. Thank you so much.